

Customs Hold and Clearance Escalation SOP

AfaqRoute Logistics Services Co. (ARLS) | Saudi Arabia Operations

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Purpose

To standardize ARLS response to customs holds, missing documents and clearance exceptions while preserving a complete evidence trail.

Scope

Applies when ARLS acts as freight forwarder, transport coordinator or clearance liaison. Official customs requirements always take precedence.

1. First 30 minutes

- Confirm hold location, broker/authority reference if available, shipment ID and exact confirmed reason.
- If the cause is not confirmed, record 'reason pending confirmation' rather than guessing.
- Check availability and consistency of the commercial invoice, packing list, transport document, certificate of origin where applicable, permits/certificates where applicable, and importer/consignee information.
- Record the latest written broker, carrier or customer communication in the shipment timeline.

2. Common document discrepancy checks

Check	Examples	Internal action
Party details	Importer name or registration mismatch	Return to account owner/importer for correction
Commercial invoice	Currency, quantity, value or item mismatch	Request corrected invoice; retain superseded copy
Transport document	Consignee, package count or routing mismatch	Coordinate amendment with carrier/forwarder
Origin evidence	Missing or invalid origin evidence where required	Escalate to shipper/origin agent
Product compliance	Permit/certificate required for regulated goods	Route to compliance owner; do not promise release time

3. Escalation clock

Elapsed hold time	Required action
0-2 hours	Clearance owner investigates and requests missing information.
2-6 hours	Customs Lead reviews unresolved cause and recovery plan.
6-24 hours	Account Owner informed; customer receives status and required action.
>24 hours	Operations Manager review; written update at least daily.
>48 hours or high-value cargo	Senior Operations review and documented mitigation decision.

4. Customer communication rules

- State confirmed facts only: location, confirmed reason, required action, responsible party and next update time.

- Never promise customs release at a specific time unless written confirmation exists from the authorized party.
- When customer documents are required, list each missing or corrected item separately.
- After release, update the movement milestone, revised ETA and any known storage/demurrage exposure.

Records and audit trail

All material actions, timestamps, approvals, customer notifications and supporting evidence must be recorded against the shipment or incident reference in the transport management system.

Control note

This internal document does not replace Saudi laws, customs instructions, carrier terms, customer contracts or directions issued by competent authorities.